irrigation and rainfed cultivation cleavage is a major influence on agricultural productivity, earning opportunities, and the welfare of the rural population.

Irrigated areas are generally more productive, return better yields, and contribute more to the national stock of staple food grains (rice and wheat). Irrigated agriculture enjoys active and ongoing support from public policy, largely because the onus of resolving the food problem for a large population pivots upon its performance in the first instance.

Statement II: CORRECT—In the northern Indo- Gangetic plains, the states of Punjab, Haryana, Uttar Pradesh, and Bihar have more than 60% of their cultivated area irrigated. Andhra Pradesh, Gujarat, Rajasthan, and West Bengal have parts of their agricultural land irrigated and depend on both monsoon rains and irrigation systems.

At the other extreme, Assam, Chhatisgarh, Himachal Pradesh, Kerala, Jharkhand, Maharashtra, Odisha, and Uttarakhand have smaller irrigated areas and are predominantly dependent upon rainfall for agricultural production.

59. Statement I: CORRECT—The water resource situation in India is rapidly worsening, and it is likely to become severe during coming decades. Per capita availability of water is low, and the water is of poor quality. The groundwater table is receding as aquifers are being emptied by excessive extraction by tube- wells and submersible pumps.

The water stress is visibly mounting in river basins. Contamination of ground water signals alarming situation. The north-west of India, which has been leading the wheat and rice revolution, is the most stressed, although as much as 54% of the country is adversely affected.

Statement II: CORRECT—Irrigation is the major user of water, accounting for more than four-fifths of the total used water. However, the system is grossly inefficient with existing infrastructure neither well maintained nor efficiently utilised. Estimates suggest that about one-fifth of the irrigation infrastructure (57 million ha) remains unutilised. Irrigation practices are in general wasteful and not geared to water